Google ads & credits

A step-by-step guide to start FileFlowHQ's ad-supported credit system. Work through it top to bottom; tick the boxes as you go.

> **The plan.** Free users see ads and **earn credits by watching rewarded ads** ("watch a short video, get 1 credit"). Credits pay for conversions and Studio exports. **Paying (Paystack) only removes ads**; it no longer buys credits.

Which Google product does what

Where	Google product	Used for
Website: banners	AdSense	Normal display ads on pages. Easiest to get approved; your first step.
Website: "watch for credits"	Google Ad Manager (rewarded web ads)	The rewarded video that gives credits. Uses your AdSense account.
iOS / Android apps	AdMob (rewarded ads)	Same reward in the Capacitor apps, with server-side verification.

Decide these first

- [ ] **Credits for paid (ad-free) users.** They no longer see ads, so they can't earn credits. Pick one: unlimited use while ad-free, or a monthly allowance (e.g. 50 credits) included in the payment.
- [ ] **Ad-free price and type.** One-off (e.g. NGN 1,500 for 30 days) or monthly subscription (Paystack Plans).
- [ ] **Credits per ad** (suggest 1) and a **daily cap** per user (suggest 5–10).
- [ ] **Can ad credits pay for Studio exports?** Today exports need a paid credit (`consumePaidUse` in api/_usage.js).

Step 0 · Get the site ready (before applying)

- [ ] fileflowhq.com is live on its own domain, with real, original content (tools, guides, About). Google rejects thin sites.
- [ ] Privacy policy page (src/pages/Privacy.jsx) mentions Google ads, cookies, and links to `policies.google.com/technologies/ads`.
- [ ] Terms page and a Contact page are reachable from the footer.
- [ ] Cookie consent: for visitors in the EEA/UK/Switzerland you need a Google-certified consent tool. The free one is in AdSense > **Privacy & messaging** > European regulations message.
- [ ] The page has a mobile viewport meta tag (needed for rewarded web ads).
- [ ] Google account you'll keep long-term (the payee name must match your bank account).

Step 1 · AdSense: sign up and get approved

1. Go to **adsense.google.com** > Get started. Enter fileflowhq.com, country **Nigeria**, and accept the terms.

2. Fill in **payment info**: legal name and address exactly as on your bank account. Add tax info if asked.
3. AdSense gives you a code snippet with your publisher ID (`ca-pub-XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX`). Add it to **index.html** inside `<head>`.
4. Create **public/ads.txt** with the line AdSense shows you, e.g.:
   `google.com, pub-XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX, DIRECT, f08c47fec0942fa0`
5. Deploy, then click **Request review** in AdSense. Approval takes from a few days to a few weeks. Don't change much meanwhile.
6. Once approved: Ads > By ad unit > create a **display ad unit** and place it in a few spots (e.g. under tool results). Never inside the PDF editor canvas.
7. When earnings reach **$10**, Google mails a **PIN letter** to your address. Enter it in AdSense. Payouts start at **$100**, paid monthly by bank transfer.

Step 2 · Rewarded ads on the website (Ad Manager)

1. Go to **admanager.google.com** and sign up for the free **Ad Manager** account with the same Google account. It links to your AdSense account. Approval may take a while.
2. Inventory > Ad units > **New ad unit**, name it `ffhq_rewarded_credit`. It will be shown as a rewarded (out-of-page) slot from code.
3. Make sure AdSense / Ad Exchange demand is allowed for that unit, and don't set a high price floor (it reduces fill).
4. Add the Google Publisher Tag script (`securepubads.g.doubleclick.net/tag/js/gpt.js`) and show the ad when a user clicks "Watch an ad for 1 credit" (code on the next page).

> **Important limits of rewarded ads on websites** (from Google's docs):
> • **No server-side verification on web.** It is app-only, so the browser tells you the ad finished, which can be faked. Use the anti-cheat steps below and keep rewards small.
> • Only on mobile-optimised pages (viewport tag, no zoom).
> • Only one rewarded ad at a time. Sometimes there is **no ad available**; show "No ad right now, try later".
> • Some ads grant the reward before the video ends: always use `rewardedSlotGranted`.

Website code sketch (React)

```
// src/utils/rewardedAd.js: show one rewarded ad;
// resolves true if the user earned the reward
export function watchRewardedAd(adUnitPath = '/NETWORK_CODE/ffhq_rewarded_credit') {
  return new Promise((resolve) => {
    const googletag = (window.googletag = window.googletag || { cmd: [] })
    googletag.cmd.push(() => {
      const slot = googletag.defineOutOfPageSlot(
        adUnitPath, googletag.enums.OutOfPageFormat.REWARDED)
      if (!slot) return resolve(false) // page/device not supported
      slot.addService(googletag.pubads())
      let granted = false
      const pubads = googletag.pubads()
      pubads.addEventListener('rewardedSlotReady', (e) => e.makeRewardedVisible())
      pubads.addEventListener('rewardedSlotGranted', () => { granted = true })
      pubads.addEventListener('rewardedSlotClosed', () => {
        googletag.destroySlots([slot])
        resolve(granted)
      })
      pubads.addEventListener('slotRenderEnded', (e) => {
        if (e.slot === slot && e.isEmpty) resolve(false) // no ad available
      })
      googletag.enableServices()
      googletag.display(slot)
    })
  })
}
```

Flow: **1)** POST `/api/ad-start` > server returns a one-time token. **2)** `watchRewardedAd()`. **3)** If true, POST `/api/ad-reward {token}` > server adds 1 credit.

Anti-cheat for the website

- [ ] Token from `/api/ad-start` is single-use, stored in Redis with a 5-minute expiry.
- [ ] Reject a reward that arrives sooner than ~15 seconds after the token was issued (no real ad is that short).
- [ ] Daily cap per client id and per IP (both already exist: `clientId`, `clientIp` in api/_usage.js).
- [ ] Ad credits can't be transferred or cashed out, so cheating only wins a few free conversions.

Step 3 · Rewarded ads in the iOS / Android apps (AdMob)

1. Go to **admob.google.com** and sign in with the same Google account (it shares AdSense payments).
2. Apps > Add app > Android (and again for iOS). Link to the store listing once published.
3. For each app: Ad units > **Rewarded** > reward amount **1**, item **credit**.
4. In the rewarded unit settings, turn on **Server-side verification** and set the callback URL to `https://fileflowhq.com/api/admob-ssv`. Use AdMob's test button to check it.
5. Install the Capacitor plugin: `npm i @capacitor-community/admob && npx cap sync`. Add your AdMob **App ID** to AndroidManifest.xml and iOS Info.plist (GADApplicationIdentifier).
6. When showing the ad, pass the user's client id as `ssv.customData` (or userId) so the callback knows who to credit.
7. iOS: show Apple's tracking prompt (App Tracking Transparency) and add `NSUserTrackingUsageDescription`; update the App Store privacy labels and Play Store data safety form (ads, device id).
8. Use **test ad unit IDs** while developing. Clicking your own live ads can get your account banned.

/api/admob-ssv must:

- [ ] Fetch Google's public keys (`gstatic.com/admob/reward/verifier-keys.json`), cache them for less than 24 hours.
- [ ] Verify the ECDSA `signature` over the query string (everything before `&signature=`) using `key_id`. Node's built-in `crypto.verify` can do it.
- [ ] Reject a `transaction_id` that was already used (store it in Redis), then add the credit to `custom_data`'s client id.

Step 4 · Code changes in FileFlowHQ

File	Change
api/_usage.js	Add earned (ad) credits; an **adFree** flag per client (with expiry if time-limited); let exports spend ad credits if you decided so.
api/ad-start.js (new)	Issue a single-use reward token (Redis, 5 min).
api/ad-reward.js (new)	Web: check token + min time + daily caps, then +1 credit.
api/admob-ssv.js (new)	Apps: verify Google's signature, dedupe transaction_id, +1 credit.
api/pay-verify.js, pay-webhook.js	A successful payment sets adFree (and its expiry) instead of adding credits.
src/context/UsageContext.jsx	Expose adFree and a `watchAdForCredit()` action.
src/components/PaywallModal.jsx	"Watch an ad for 1 credit" (main) + "Go ad-free" (Paystack).
src/components/StudioExportGate.jsx	Out of credits > offer an ad instead of only Paystack.
src/components/AdSlot.jsx (new)	Banner component; renders nothing when adFree or on native.
index.html, public/ads.txt	AdSense script + ads.txt line.
src/pages/Privacy.jsx	Explain ads, cookies, consent, and that files still never leave the device.
vercel.json / CSP	Allow Google ad domains if you add a Content-Security-Policy.

Step 5 · Launch checklist

- [ ] Test everything with Google's **test ads** first; never click your own live ads.
- [ ] Rewarded button only appears when an ad actually loaded; handle "no ad available".
- [ ] Paid users: no banners, no rewarded prompts, in web and apps.
- [ ] Consent banner shows in the EU/UK; ads still work (non-personalised) when people decline.
- [ ] Watch AdSense / Ad Manager reports for the first week: fill rate, eCPM, invalid traffic warnings.
- [ ] Keep ads off the editor canvas and away from buttons (accidental clicks break policy).

Rules that get accounts banned

- [ ] Clicking your own ads, or asking people to click ads.
- [ ] Rewarding a click (rewarding a watched rewarded ad is fine; that's what the format is for).
- [ ] Ads on pages with no content (e.g. a bare loading screen) or overlapping app controls.
- [ ] Buying junk traffic.

Useful links

AdSense: `adsense.google.com` · Ad Manager: `admanager.google.com` · AdMob: `admob.google.com`

Rewarded web ads (requirements): `support.google.com/admanager/answer/9116812`

GPT rewarded sample: `developers.google.com/publisher-tag/samples/display-rewarded-ad`

AdMob server-side verification: `developers.google.com/admob/android/ssv`

Capacitor plugin: `github.com/capacitor-community/admob`

Checked against Google's docs in October 2026. Google changes programs and thresholds; confirm amounts ($10 PIN, $100 payout) in your account.